

(This text is taken from the Stoic philosophical work "Enchiridion" — The Handbook — by Epictetus.)

THE HANDBOOK (ENCHIRIDION)

Chapter 1

1.1. Some things are in our control and others not.

Things in our control are opinion, pursuit, desire, aversion, and, in a word, whatever are our own actions.

Things not in our control are body, property, reputation, command, and, in one word, whatever are not our own actions.

2. The things in our control are by nature free, unrestrained, unhindered;

but those not in our control are weak, slavish, restrained, belonging to others.
3. Remember, then, that if you suppose that things which are slavish by nature are also free,

and that what belongs to others is your own,

then you will be hindered, you will lament, you will be disturbed,

and you will find fault both with gods and men.

But if you suppose that only to be your own which is your own,

and what belongs to others such as it really is,

then no one will ever compel you or restrain you.

Further, you will find fault with no one or accuse no one.

You will do nothing against your will.

No one will hurt you,

you will have no enemies,

and not anything harmful will happen to you.
4. Aiming therefore at such great things, remember that you must not allow yourself to be carried, even with a slight effort, toward these other things,

but that you must utterly give up some things,

and for the present postpone others.

But if you wish to attain these great things (wisdom, inner freedom) and simultaneously pursue power and riches,

you may probably lose the very latter,

because you aim at the former too;

and you will certainly fail to attain the former (happiness and freedom),

by which alone real happiness and freedom are procured.

5. Work, therefore, to say to every harsh impression (appearance):

"You are but an impression,

and not at all what you seem to be."

And then examine it by those rules which you possess,

especially by this first rule:

whether it concerns the things which are in our control,

or those which are not;

and if it concerns anything not in our control,

be prepared to say:

"It is nothing to me."

Chapter 2

1. Remember that desire promises the attainment of that of which you are desirous;

and aversion promises the avoiding of that to which you are averse.

However, he who fails to obtain the object of his desire is unfortunate,

and he who falls into that which he would avoid incurs misfortune.

If then you confine your aversion only to those things which are contrary to nature (such as vice, injustice),

and which are within your own control,
you will never fall into anything that you would avoid.
But if you attempt to avoid disease, or death, or poverty,
which are not in your control,
you will be wretched.

2. Remove aversion, then, from all things that are not in our control,
and transfer it to things contrary to nature that are within our control.
For the present, suppress desire completely.
For if you desire any of the things which are not within your control,
you must inevitably be disappointed.
And of those things which are within your control and which are proper to desire,
none are yet within your possession.
Use only your impulses to act and not to act (motivation);
yet do this lightly, with moderation,
without straining, and with reservation.

Chapter 3

3. With regard to everything that gives you delight, or is useful, or is deeply loved,
get into the habit of reminding yourself what its nature is.
Begin with the most insignificant things.
If you are fond of a jug, say to yourself:
"This is a jug that I am fond of."
Then, if it gets broken, you will not be disturbed.
If you are kissing your child or your wife, say to yourself:

"I am kissing a mortal human being."

And then, if either of them dies, you will not be grieved.

Chapter 4

When you are about to undertake any action, remind yourself what manner of action it is. If you are going to bathe, picture to yourself the things which usually happen in public baths: some people splashing water, some jostling, some abusing each other, and some stealing...

You will undertake your action much more securely if you proceed with this thought:

"I wish to bathe, and simultaneously to maintain my will in harmony with nature."

And apply this to every single action.

If anything hinders you while bathing, be prepared to say to yourself:

"It was not merely bathing that I desired,

but also to keep my will in harmony with nature.

And I shall not keep it so if I lose my temper."

Chapter 5

Men are disturbed not by things themselves,

but by the views which they take of things.

For example, death is nothing terrible in itself—otherwise it would have appeared so to Socrates too.

No; the terror consists in our judgment that death is terrible.

Therefore, whenever we are hindered, or disturbed, or grieved,

let us never attribute it to others,

but only to ourselves—that is, to our own judgments.

To blame others for one's own misfortunes is the sign of an uneducated person.

To blame oneself is the first step toward education.

To blame neither others nor oneself is the mark of a person whose education is complete.

Chapter 6

Be not elated at any excellence that is not your own.

If a horse should say proudly, "I am handsome," this might be tolerated.

But when you boast, "I have a handsome horse,"

know that what you take pride in is merely a good quality belonging to the horse.

What, then, is your own?

The way you deal with impressions (sensory or mental appearances).

When you handle these impressions in accordance with nature,

then you may take pride in yourself—

for then you will be boasting of an excellence that is truly your own.

Chapter 7

Suppose you are on a voyage and your ship drops anchor in a harbor.

When you go ashore to fetch water,

you may pick up a few shells or a bulb along the way;

yet you must keep your mind fixed on the ship,

and constantly look back lest the captain should call.
And if the captain calls,
you must immediately drop all these trifles and run to the ship,
lest you be bound and thrown on board like sheep.
So it is in life.
If, instead of a little shell or a bulb,
a wife and a child are given to you,
there is nothing wrong with that.
Yet when the captain (God, fate) calls,
you must leave all these behind and run to the ship without once looking back.
And if you are old,
never stray far from the ship,
lest you fail to be ready when the call comes.

Chapter 8

Do not demand that things should happen as you wish them to;
rather, wish that they happen just as they do happen—
and then you will have a tranquil and happy life.

Chapter 9

Sickness is a hindrance to the body,
but not to the will (faculty of choice)—
unless the will itself decides to let it be a hindrance.
Lameness is a hindrance to the leg,
but not to the will.
Say this to yourself with regard to everything that befalls you;
for you will find that these things are a hindrance to something else,
but not to you.

Chapter 10

Upon every occurrence, remember to turn into yourself and inquire what faculty you possess to deal with it.
If you see a handsome man or a beautiful woman, you will find within yourself the faculty of temperance (self-control) to resist it.
If hard labor is laid upon you, you will find fortitude.
If you are reviled, you will find patience.
And if you make this a habit, your impressions (passions) will not carry you away.

Chapter 11

Never say of anything, "I have lost it";
say instead:
"I have given it back."
Is your child dead? — It is given back.
Is your wife dead? — She is given back.
"My farm was taken from me." — That too is given back.
"Yes, but the man who took it was a rascal!" you might say.

What difference does it make to you by whose hands the giver demands it back?
So long as it is entrusted to you, care for it as something that does not belong to you;
just as a traveler regards an inn.

Chapter 12

1. If you wish to make progress, cast aside such reasoning as:

"If I neglect my affairs, I will have no livelihood."

"If I do not punish my slave, he will be spoiled."

For it is better to die of hunger, exempt from grief and fear,
than to live in affluence with perturbation.

And it is better that your slave should be bad than that you should be wretched.

Begin, therefore, with little things.

2. Is a little oil spilled? Is a little wine stolen?

Say immediately to yourself:

"This is the price paid for tranquility;

this is the cost of peace of mind."

Nothing is bought without a price.

When you call your slave, keep in mind that he may not answer your call;

and even if he does answer, he may not do what you want.

However, it is not so well with him that your tranquility should depend upon his pleasure.

Chapter 13

If you wish to make progress,
be content to appear foolish and simple with regard to external things.

Do not wish to appear to know anything about them.

And if you should appear to be somebody to some people,
distrust yourself.

For you must know that it is not easy

both to keep your will in harmony with nature,
and at the same time to hold on to external things.
If you fix your attention on one of them,
you are bound to neglect the other.

Chapter 14

1. If you wish your children, your wife, or your friends to live forever,
you are foolish;

for you wish things that are not in your control to be in your control,
and you count what belongs to others as your own.

In the same manner, if you wish that your slave should make no mistakes,
you are a fool;

for you wish vice not to be vice—

which is contrary to nature.

But if you wish never to fail in your desires,

that is in your own power.

Train yourself, therefore, in what you are able to achieve.

2. Every person's master is he who has the power over the things that person desires or avoids,
to confer them or to take them away.

Whoever, then, would be free,

let him neither desire nor avoid anything that is in the power of others.

Otherwise, he will inevitably be a slave.

Chapter 15

Remember that you ought to behave in life as you would at a banquet.
When a dish is passed around and arrives before you,
put out your hand and take a moderate share politely.
Does it pass by you? Do not try to stop it.

Has it not yet reached you? Do not stretch your desire towards it,
but wait until it arrives before you.
So act with regard to children, wife, public offices, and wealth.
Then you will one day be a worthy guest at the banquets of the gods.
And if you do not even take the things that are set before you,
but despise them,
then you will not only be a guest at the feast of the gods,
but will also share their rule.
For by acting in this way,
men such as Diogenes and Heraclitus
were deservedly called divine.

Chapter 16

When you see someone weeping in grief—
because a child has gone away, or possessions are lost—
take care:
Try to understand whether this person is truly made miserable by these external events
or rather by the judgment formed about those events.
Immediately say to yourself:
"What disturbs him is not what has happened;
for another person might suffer the same occurrence
and not be grieved in this way.
What grieves him is his own judgment about the event."
Yet, do not hesitate to show empathy in your speech;
if necessary, groan with him.
Only take care that you do not groan within yourself as well.

Chapter 17

Remember that you are an actor in a drama.
The play may be short or long, according to the author's will.
If the author chooses that you should act the part of a beggar,
see that you act even this role as naturally and skillfully as you can.
In the same manner, if he chooses for you to play the role of a cripple, a public official,
or a private person,
play that character with the same care and excellence.

1. General Summary and Main Idea

The first seventeen sections of Epictetus' *Enchiridion* teach that a person's happiness depends not on external events, but on their own judgments and attitudes.

Main idea:

It is not things themselves that disturb people, but the opinions they form about things.

According to Stoic philosophy, the goal of life is to live in harmony with nature, guided by reason and freedom from emotional disturbance.

Epictetus emphasizes that we must distinguish between what is within our control (our choices, judgments, desires) and what is not within our control (wealth, health, death, the actions of others).

Happiness comes from focusing only on what we can control and accepting everything else as part of nature's order.

In short:

- We cannot control events, but we can control our reactions.
- Everything happens according to nature's law.
- The wise person accepts this order calmly, without complaint or resistance.

2. Key Quotations (You can underline these in your PDF)

These are the central Stoic ideas you should highlight for class or exams:

- **Section 1 – What depends on us and what doesn't:**

“Some things are up to us, and some are not up to us.”

Importance: This is the foundation of all Stoic philosophy. Our will, judgment, and moral choices are up to us; wealth, fame, and death are not.

- **Section 3 – Remember the nature of what you love:**

“If you're fond of a jug, say, ‘This is a jug that I'm fond of’; and then, if it gets broken, you won't be upset.”

Importance: Recognize the fragility of what you love to avoid unnecessary suffering. Awareness replaces emotional attachment.

- **Section 4 – Think before every action:**

“When you're about to embark on any action, remind yourself what kind of action it is.”

Importance: Expect difficulties in every situation. If you anticipate what might happen, you will remain calm and act in accordance with reason.

- **Section 5 – It's not events but judgments that disturb us:**

“It isn't the things themselves that disturb people, but the judgments that they form about them.”

Importance: Perhaps the most famous Stoic principle. Nothing external is inherently good or bad; only our interpretations make them so.

- **Section 6 – True pride is in inner virtue:**

“Don’t pride yourself on any excellence that is not your own.”

Importance: External achievements or possessions are not truly ours. We should take pride only in the right use of reason and impressions, for that is our own virtue.

- **Section 7 – Life as a voyage:**

“If the captain calls, you must give up all of these things and run to the ship.”

Importance: Life is temporary. When nature (or God) calls us back—through death—we must leave everything without resistance.

- **Section 8 – Wish for things to happen as they do:**

“Don’t seek that all that comes about should come about as you wish, but wish that everything that comes about should come about just as it does.”

Importance: Happiness is not making events fit your will, but aligning your will with the course of nature.

- **Section 9 – External obstacles don’t touch inner freedom:**

“Disease is an impediment to the body, but not to choice.”

Importance: Bodily suffering cannot harm the will. True freedom lies in mental attitude, not in external circumstances.

3. Philosophical Commentary (for a Philosophy Course)

This text represents the ethical essence of Stoicism. Below is how you can interpret it academically:

- **A) Epistemological aspect (knowledge and perception):**

According to Epictetus, we cannot control the external world, but we can control how we interpret our impressions (*phantasiai*). Wisdom means evaluating impressions correctly, using reason (*logos*). This defines the Stoic view of rational knowledge.

- **B) Ethical aspect:**

Good and evil do not lie in external things, but in our choices (*prohairesis*). Moral virtue consists in bringing our will into harmony with divine reason (nature). To “live according to nature” means to live according to reason — this is the Stoic definition of a virtuous life.

- **C) Psychological aspect:**

Epictetus does not advocate repressing emotions, but understanding their cause. Emotions such as anger, fear, or grief arise not from events themselves but from false beliefs about those events. Thus, philosophy becomes a kind of mental therapy, anticipating modern cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT).

- **D) Theological / existential aspect:**

Humans are part of nature's divine order and cannot oppose it. Death is a natural process, not an evil. The wise person accepts mortality calmly, seeing it as part of universal reason.

- **E) Philosophical conclusion:**

Epictetus teaches:

- Emotional autonomy
- The supremacy of reason
- Harmony with nature as the foundation of virtue

Hence: Human happiness lies not in external circumstances, but in how we use our mind and reason.

Concise Summary Sentence (Good for exams or essays):

Epictetus argues that human beings control only their judgments and choices, and true happiness arises from recognizing this fact and living in harmony with nature. It is not events but our interpretations of them that disturb us; therefore, the wise person accepts reality as it is and maintains inner peace through self-mastery.